

6.2 Networks

Broadband Internet has suddenly become the rage in urban India. ISPs and local operators have started providing broadband connections and suddenly, most computers have miraculously grown a LAN card!

LAN cards are available for as low as Rs 650 and you can get one from the local hardware shop and install it. This is in a way good as most ISPs bundle in a LAN card at an extra charge, which could be more than the market price of just the card. Also, the brand of LAN card may not be to your liking. Thus, shopping for your own LAN card gives you the freedom to choose, what you think is right for you. Most new motherboards come with on-board LAN cards, which can be utilised right away. In fact, some boards bundle a normal LAN card chip plus a gigabit LAN card chip. Gigabit LAN is a new technology that allows for data transfer rates of about 1000 Mbps compared to the present LAN which allows only upto 100 Mbps. This makes such boards future-ready.

Having a LAN card not only helps you connect to the Internet, but also share information and data from one PC to another that, in other conditions, would be not feasible. For example, transferring around 20 GB of data from one computer to another will definitely involve the use of external storage or at least the removal of a hard drive from one of the computers. However, if both computers are connected over the network, sharing of data can be done easily although it will take some time to transfer the data. But the moot point is that the data can be transferred without hassles, which would not have been possible in the absence of a network.

So far, we have seen how to connect to the Internet using a modem. In this part, we will see how to network computers briefly and how to connect to the Internet using a LAN card. For connecting to the Internet using a broadband connection, you will have to contact any ISP such as BSNL, Sify, Iqara or any of the other ISPs and they will give you the necessary instructions to set up the Internet protocol or IP address. How to do that is explained below.